

DUBIOUS DISTINCTION

West Bengal witnesses most student suicides...

WEST BENGAL	940	WEST BENGAL	1,138	WEST BENGAL	1,141	WEST BENGAL	731
MAHARASHTRA	757	MAHARASHTRA	793	MAHARASHTRA	882	MAHARASHTRA	784
ANDHRA PRADESH	481	ANDHRA PRADESH	699	ANDHRA PRADESH	512	TAMIL NADU	531
KARNATAKA	455	KARNATAKA	507	KARNATAKA	447	ANDHRA PRADESH	500
CHHATTISGARH	370	MADHYA PRADESH	326	MADHYA PRADESH	365	KARNATAKA	368

RURAL SKEW

... but unlike other states, it remains a rural phenomenon

DELHI	150	DELHI	120	CHENNAI	226	CHENNAI	103
MUMBAI	88	CHENNAI	117	MUMBAI	101	DELHI	89
BANGALORE	84	BANGALORE	116	DELHI	100	MUMBAI	84
CHENNAI	77	MUMBAI	82	BANGALORE	90	BANGALORE	76
KOLKATA	13	KOLKATA	11	KOLKATA	13	KOLKATA	15

Source: National Crime Records Bureau

Almost 60 per cent of the suicide cases are reported from the suburbs and rural areas while those from the urban elite are usually not allowed to become public knowledge. Sociologist Agrim Chanda feels that the politics of the region is to be blamed. "In a way, yes, it's the communist philosophy gone awry. The 50-year-olds in the rural belts are mainly Left voters and are, by definition, strait-jacketed into a certain worldview. Their children are growing up in a totally different world; they want most of everything. Priorities are different but the parents do not understand this. Even love affairs are resisted. Careers are often chosen by parents. All this leads you nowhere and in a sudden rush of blood, what you do is commit suicide. In most cases, we have evidence that the action was meant to shock the parents," says Chanda.

Statistics, however, prove that most suicides in the state are reported

from small towns and rural middle-class. Sociologist Arindam Sen says, "Children from smaller towns are more prone to suicides in Bengal. Interestingly, pesticides, which are freely available, are the main killers. The suicide figure is very low in Kolkata as compared to other metros because of traditional family views of brushing such news under the carpet and in most cases, not reporting it to the police. Also, children in Kolkata do not lead a high-strung jet-age life high on web, drugs, liquor like in Mumbai or Bangalore. Also, family bonds are stronger here."

Schools and colleges try to look the other way and the counselling centres pay only lip service. The principal of a well-known elite school, on condition of anonymity, blamed it on the lack of awareness on the part of NGOs. "They don't know how to campaign. One bright summer morning, they will pitch camp and address students.

There is, however, no follow-up action. I think that is primary. The attention span of students nowadays is very little. The need to stay alive and contribute positively to the society needs to be drilled in constantly. That is lacking for sure. Schools cannot afford to take out time for this," he says.

Even the doctors are confused and angry. "Unlike the West, we don't have anything like psychological autopsy here. This is the reason why and how quacks take advantage and pose as psychiatrists and counsellors. They confuse people more. Only the other day, a student of an elite English-medium school in the city committed suicide. The entire family, instead of trying to see the situation in the correct perspective, is now in denial. This does not help our cause," says Dr J.R. Ramesh of Apollo Hospitals. He is quick to point out that these suicide figures may not always point to the real thing. "If we go by awareness or the education indicators, Kerala or Puducherry shouldn't have cases of suicide given their high literacy rate. The malaise is deeper than what is being thought." The tragedy is that nobody seems to have a clue how deep. ■

SUICIDE FIGURES IN THE STATE ARE MOSTLY FROM SMALL TOWNS AND NOT CITIES AS MIDDLE CLASS FAMILIES SEEK TO HUSH THINGS UP.